

Dates are stored as floating point numbers. The integer part of the date is the number of days since Jan 1, 1900. The decimal part is the amount of time since midnight. .00 is midnight, .25 is 6 AM, .50 is noon, etc. This means that any date can be formatted as a decimal number. To see the many ways that numbers can appear in Excel, have a look at the table below. The value 38027.375 was placed in each cell appearing on the left side of the table.

In Excel, it looks like...	when formatted with:
10/2/04 9:00 AM	d/m/yy h:mm AM/PM
10/02/04	dd/mm/yy
Tuesday, 10/02/2004	dddd, dd/mm/yyyy
Tuesday	dddd
Feb 10, 2004	mmmm dd, yyyy
38,027	#,###
38,027.38	#,###.00
38.0K	#.0,K
.04M	#.00,,\M

Each cell was then formatted differently while leaving the value in the cell untouched. The first five formats of the table show a sampling of date formats. Some are quite normal and show date or date and time. One is a bit strange and shows only the day of the week. It's hard to imagine 38,027.375 appearing as only 'Tuesday'!

From the sixth example onwards, we're treating the value not as a date, but as a standard number. The formats in the bottom right show how to affect the number of decimals to display as well as how many numbers to the left of the decimal to display. Note that a comma will remove three digits from a number—38,027 becomes 38. A 'K' is placed at the end to denote thousands. Two commas will replace 6 digits. In this case, a '\M' is used to denote millions as opposed to just 'M' which has already been used for months.